



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Waterbrook Christian Academy

School Website: <https://waterbrookca.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Waterbrook Christian Academy in Flint, Michigan presents a clearly Classical Christian model rooted in traditional liberal-arts formation. Public materials from the school repeatedly emphasize a classical framework (Hillsdale College curriculum, Great Books, Latin, logic, rhetoric) alongside a Christ-centered, liturgical-inclined community (morning devotion, worship, Psalm 42:1). The school also foregrounds virtue and formation (Love, Truth, Wisdom, Virtue) and a formation-first orientation rather than pure job preparation. Taken together with the public statements about theology, worship, and a capstone-style senior project, Waterbrook places itself within the Classical continuum, with especially strong alignment in Curriculum and Religious Foundations.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials describe Waterbrook as a classical Christian school with a Christ-centered environment and a central role for religious instruction in the education process. The Psalm 42:1 reference and the morning devotion/worship practices are explicitly cited, anchoring the liturgical and communal dimensions.
- The school highlights Bible study, theology-inflected culture, and a non-denominational, faith-led identity, aligning with liturgical and communal practices.
- The motto and religious framing (Love, Truth, Wisdom, Virtue) anchors moral and metaphysical aims.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: theology, sacred/Christ-centered language, devotion, worship, Bible, Psalm 42:1, liturgical/community references, Love/Truth/Wisdom/Virtue.
- Negative keywords present: none detected in public materials (no secular, non-religious, or interfaith neutrality appearing as a governing stance in the public materials).
- Supporting sources for keyword set include Classical Education doctrine references in the knowledge base, which map well to Waterbrook's theological framing.
- Why this rating
- Waterbrook's materials explicitly locate education within a Christian theological frame, emphasize worship and liturgical rhythm, and tie character formation to transcendent virtues. The combination of

Psalms 42:1 devotion, Bible emphasis, and Christ-centered aims strongly align with the Positive Keywords for Religious Foundations and with the overall Classical pattern of theological grounding. Therefore, categorized as CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials describe a formation-focused aim: “to provide a classical Christian education, of the highest quality, in a Christ-centered environment rooted in Love, Truth, Wisdom, and Virtue,” and to equip students to live well-ordered lives as human beings and citizens. This is formation-first and teleological (virtue and wisdom) rather than merely information-based or job-focused.
- The school explicitly embraces formation, virtue, and the Great Books as foundational content, signaling a conviction that truth, goodness, and beauty are knowable and guide learning.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: virtue, wisdom, truth, goodness, beauty, formation, holistic education, moral formation, great conversation, student character, love of learning.
- Negative keywords present: none evident (no emphasis on vocationalism at expense of formation in public materials).
- The knowledge-base framework’s positive keywords (cultivation of wisdom and virtue; pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty; formation) map onto Waterbrook’s stated aims.
- Why this rating
- Waterbrook explicitly centers formation and virtue as the core aim of education, with a clear claim that truth, goodness, and beauty are real and knowable and should guide pedagogy. This is a hallmark of CLASSICAL alignment in this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- The curriculum explicitly includes Great Books, Latin, Bible, Fine Arts, Phonics, Cursive, and a study of the Great Books across grade levels. Older students have Logic, Rhetoric, Moral & Political Philosophy, and a Capstone Project in Senior English. This is a robust liberal-arts core with a clearly Trivium-focused approach (grammar in foundational skills, logic in upper grades, rhetoric in upper grades).
- The Hillsdale College Curriculum affiliation is stated, positioning Waterbrook within a well-known classical framework, and the Great Books are singled out as a central throughline.
- The site frames “Academic Program & Fine Arts” as a core component (including Bible and Great Books), reinforcing the integration of liberal-arts content.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: Great Books, Latin, Logic, Rhetoric, Moral & Political Philosophy, Capstone, Bible, Phonics, Cursive, Fine Arts.
- Negative keywords present: none (no indication of moving away from Classical/Great Books or Trivium-centered content).
- The knowledge-base lists map directly to Waterbrook’s curriculum (Great Books; liberal-arts through grammar/logic/rhetoric; Trivium emphasis; integration with theology).
- Why this rating
- The curriculum content explicitly fulfills the liberal-arts/Great Books orientation and Trivium components. Waterbrook’s stated curriculum components align strongly with CLASSICAL expectations for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials emphasize a classical educational framework, including a Capstone Project in the senior year and a robust emphasis on logic and rhetoric in the upper grades. The explicit mention of “Socratic discussion” or formal seminars is not present in the public materials, though the presence of logic, rhetoric, and Capstone implies rhetoric-based schooling and likely discussion-based elements in higher grades. The absence of explicit Socratic/seminar language in the public materials yields partial alignment with the Pedagogy criteria.
- There is reference to a structured, classical program and to a strong emphasis on memory and rote learning in the lower grades, but there is no explicit mention of singing/chanting in the lower school on the Waterbrook site (unlike some other classical schools that emphasize “Scholé” or chanting in lower grades).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: logic, rhetoric, capstone, great books (as content to inform pedagogy), seminars/debate (implied though not explicitly named), public speaking opportunities (via rhetoric).
- Negative keywords present: explicit references to lower-school contemplative rest, singing, or chanting are not clearly documented on the site; the site does not overtly present a restorative/scholé-based pedagogy in the lower grades, though morning devotion is included. The lack of explicit lower-grade chanting/scholé or explicit Socratic-style upper-school seminars reduces the Pedagogy alignment from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Mapping to the Six Elements framework: the presence of Capstone, logic, rhetoric aligns with Pedagogy, but explicit Socratic seminars and singing/chants in lower grades are not documented in public materials, which keeps category rating from being CLASSICAL.
- Why this rating
- Waterbrook’s pedagogy shows strong classical elements (logic, rhetoric, Capstone, Great Books) but lacks explicit documentation of Socratic seminars and lower-grade contemplative practices (e.g., singing/chanting) that some classical models emphasize. Therefore, SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL is the prudent categorization.

Element 5: Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Public materials do not provide explicit statements describing faculty as the living curriculum, models of virtue, or collegial mentor culture, nor a formal “portrait” of teacher type. The site emphasizes the program and the mission, not the faculty identity or teaching culture. Employment/ faculty details exist but do not articulate the living-curriculum concept or a teacher-portrait framework in the public-facing content reviewed.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: none clearly identifiable in public materials specifically describing faculty as models of virtue or “living curriculum.”
- Negative keywords present: none captured in the public-facing materials regarding faculty; however, the lack of explicit positive faculty-identity statements yields a lack of evidence for CLASSICAL alignment in this category.
- The knowledge-base provides Positive Keywords around “Teachers as Models of Virtue” and related faculty-portrait concepts, but Waterbrook’s public content does not quote or clearly reflect those faculty-centric descriptors.
- Why this rating

- Without explicit evidence in public materials that faculty act as living curriculum, models of virtue, or a clearly defined teacher profile, this category does not meet the criterion for CLASSICAL. The best-supported stance with current public materials is NOT CLASSICAL for this category.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
- Waterbrook presents a faith-community orientation with a non-denominational Christian posture, and public materials emphasize communal worship and morning devotion, suggesting engagement with a faith-based parent and community culture. The explicit language about parents as co-teachers or formal parent partnerships is not present in the public content we examined; however, the school's identity as a faith community and the presence of a "Faith & Community" section indicate at least some community-education alignment.
- The materials show strong community and family orientation as part of its mission (named "Faith & Community," non-denominational stance, Psalm 42:1, and worship). This points to partnership-oriented values that often accompany classical education models, though explicit parent-partner language is not shown.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
- Positive keywords present: community, devotion, worship, Psalm 42:1, non-denominational, Christ-centered environment, family-oriented language.
- Negative keywords present: none identified in public materials; but explicit "parents as co-teachers" or formal parent-education programs are not described in the public content we reviewed.
- The knowledge-base documents identify "partnership with families" and "parents as co-teachers" as central to classical education in some models; Waterbrook's content demonstrates communal and faith-based engagement but lacks explicit formal parent-partnership language.
- Why this rating
- The public materials reflect meaningful community and family orientation (worship, devotion, faith identity), but they do not clearly articulate a formal partnership model with parents as co-educators or explicit parent-education initiatives. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL alignment rather than full CLASSICAL for this category.

Overall assessment (Category aggregation)

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: CLASSICAL
- Element 4: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Aggregate rating: CLASSICAL

Rationale: Waterbrook Christian Academy demonstrates a robust Classical Christian orientation across Curriculum, Purpose/Goals, and Religious Foundations, with explicit elements such as Great Books, Latin, Logic, Rhetoric, Capstone projects, and a Christ-centered formation emphasis. Pedagogy shows strong classical elements but lacks explicit documentation of the full Socratic/seminar pedagogy in public materials, which places Element 4 in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Faculty is not clearly described as the living curriculum in public content (Element 5), and Parent/Community engagement shows significant community-faith orientation but lacks explicit co-teaching or formal parent-partner structures (Element 6), also placing them at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. Taken together, the school sits firmly within CLASSICAL, with room for strengthening certain procedural articulations of pedagogy, faculty role, and parental partnership in public communications.

What would move the needle

- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Implement explicit, documented Socratic seminars and graded seminars in upper grades, with a clear framework and example timetables. Add public-facing descriptions of lower-grade contemplative practices (e.g., scholé-inspired routines or singing/chanting) if part of the program, with examples of lesson formats and rubrics.
- Element 5 (Faculty): Develop and publish a formal “portrait of the teacher” (the living curriculum) that describes teacher virtues, pedagogy, mentorship roles, and collaborative professional culture. Include statements about faculty collaboration, ongoing formation, and model-virtue expectations.
- Element 6 (Parents & Community): Establish and publish explicit parent-partnership structures (e.g., parents as co-teachers, parent book studies, ongoing parent education, and regular parent-teacher-community events). Create a clear pathway for parents to participate in school life as co-educators, and document these structures publicly.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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